

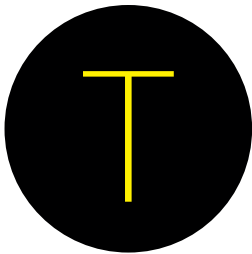


BY T.V. MOHANDAS PAI

Maintaining India's Tech Leadership

Backed by a cultural ethos of creating knowledge systems for public welfare in the public domain, India will be at the forefront of the world's digitalisation and tech-democratisation movement

188 |



TODAY, INDIA IS undoubtedly among the Top 3 digital powers in the world in terms of the percentage of digitally involved citizens among the population and the total quantum of businesses and start-ups with a robust digital presence. India has become a densely networked country with 1.2 billion mobile connections and 850 million internet connections, with among the cheapest data costs in the world. Nearly 150,000 *gram* panchayats have been connected with optic fibre to benefit rural citizens.

India also has the unique distinction of having built population-scale digital public goods (DPGs)—a set of networked, interoperable, multiplatform public utilities like Aadhaar, UPI, e-KYC, Account Aggrega-

tor (AA), Open Credit Enablement Network (OCEN), Open Network for Digital Commerce (ONDC) and more—upon which innovators can build world-class apps and platforms using open APIs. This unique public-private partnership model has removed the threat of digital monopolies developing in critical socio-economic areas and led to a flowering of innovation in the country. Human capital is abundantly available, and the DPG platforms are a unique Indian innovation based on a millennia-old cultural ethos of creating knowledge systems for public welfare in the public domain.

As India looks ahead at the next 25 years in the run-up to the 100 years of Indian independence, it is safe to say the country will be at the forefront of the world's digitalisation and technology democratisation movement. The nation will also ensure that digitalisation continues to underpin India's socio-economic accomplishments. At a time when a significant amount of capital is entering the technology ecosystem globally, Indian human capital will be the bedrock on which the economy will grow, and India will remain

a global leader. By 2025, India will have the most significant number of people working in technology. Population projections indicate this will continue till 2050 as the working-age population in India increases while the rest of the world ages, barring Africa.

As India develops further in the digital world, the nation must invest in future-forward technologies like quantum computing, artificial intelligence, machine learning, 3D printing, genomics, IoT and others where innovation happens in big bursts and which have the capability to improve human productivity and quality of life.

The government must set up policies and direct investment towards the onward movement of India's digital revolution. The approach must foster innovation, R&D in futuristic technology areas, create a large cohort of Master's and PhD scholars, and continue developing the DPG networks that are essential for India to grow rapidly and sustainably. When India hits the 100-year mark, there will possibly be three large powers—the US and Europe, India and emerging market